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Conservancy doles out fire mitigation funds

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The Santa Monica Mountains Conservancy announced it has awarded $3.2 million in state funds to Los Angeles County and Ventura County Fire Departments to implement wildfire prevention programs that will improve local fire prevention and resiliency before the next fire season begins and address the growing severity of fire seasons in Southern California.

The grants include $2.2 million to the Los Angeles County Fire Department and $1 million to the Ventura County Fire Department. The money will help local cities—including Malibu, Calabasas, Agoura Hills, Westlake Village, Simi Valley, Moorpark and Thousand Oaks—to reduce fuels in densely vegetated parks, open space and wildland urban interfaces adjacent to communities in the Santa Monica Mountains Zone and Rim of the Valley Corridor.

The Legislature enacted a measure authored by local Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (AB-100) and signed into law by Gov. Gavin Newsom in mid-April that allows the conservancy to expend Proposition 4 bond funds for urgent wildfire prevention and resilience efforts now.

Prop. 4 was approved by the voters in the November 2024 general election. The conservancy, which has helped preserve more than 85,000 acres of local open space and habitat, was allocated $31 million from Prop. 4 for watershed improvement, wildfire resilience, chaparral and forest restoration, and workforce development.

The grants to the fire departments were the first of many SMMC will award from these funds as soon as possible to proactively reduce the risk of wildfire, strengthen wildfire resilience, increase carbon sequestration, rally against the effects of climate change, and dedicate more resources to local community infrastructure.

Senator Ben Allen and Assemblymember Jaqui Irwin, whose districts include homes from Calabasas west to Camarillo and Moorpark that were impacted by the January 2025 Palisades fire, championed the early action funding to the conservancy.

"Wildfire experts from both the Los Angeles and Ventura County Fire Departments continue to work hard to ensure the safety of residents living in these areas however, their safety will be greatly enhanced through additional wildfire mitigation and the much-needed fuel reduction plans funded by these grants," Irwin said.

High intensity wildfires in the Santa Monica Mountains and Rim of the Valley Corridor Zone have become more and more common in recent years, driven primarily by weather-most famously the Santa Ana and sundowner winds.

In January, the devastating Palisades, Eaton,and Kenneth wildfires underscored an urgent need for wildfire and climate resilience efforts to address the growing severity of fire seasons in Southern California.

—Acorn staff report

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